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Local Legislators Visit Israel, Volunteers Prep Meals for Food Insecure

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Los Angeles Jewish community leaders, including California state senators and assembly members, traveled overseas for an Israel solidarity mission on Feb. 14-17.

Marking the first time many of the mission's participants had visited Israel since the Oct. 7 attack, the three-day trip was organized by Jewish Federation Los Angeles (JFEDLA), JCRC Bay Area and Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California (JPAC).

During the trip, legislators witnessed firsthand the consequences of the atrocities committed by Hamas, including site visits to impacted communities in the south along Israel's border with Gaza, meetings with families of remaining hostages and discussions with Israeli government leadership.

The group — led by California Legislative Jewish Caucus Co-Chairs Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), an assemblymember, and State Senator Scott Wiener (D-San Francisco) — visited Hostage Square in Tel Aviv, the Supernova Music Festival site, the Israeli Knesset, the Old City and the Negev, among other places. They met with Israeli President Isaac Herzog and members of the Knesset, as well as Bedouin, LGBTQIA and women leaders.

"Made with Love," a special Our Big Kitchen LA (OBKLA) volunteer session, was held last month in honor of Black History Month.

The Feb. 15 event at OBKLA, a community-run, nondenominational kitchen space on Pico Boulevard, brought together Black and Jewish influencers to prepare hundreds of meals, which were then distributed to three community youth shelters in Watts run by Roc Era, a L.A.-based youth enrichment organization.

The evening's program was part of a larger effort to combat food insecurity in the South L.A. area's underserved communities. Participants, including co-hosts Jonah Platt and Malynda Hale, said the gathering was important because it emphasized unity and community as well as dedication to supporting Black and Brown youth in need.

"In honor of Black History Month, I really wanted to bring the Black and Jewish communities together for a good cause," Hale, a curriculum development consultant at Roc Era, said. "So, when Yona Elishis, a board member for OBKLA, approached me about doing an event, I jumped at the chance."

"Creating community together in support of one another and in service to others is such dearly needed nourishment for the soul," said Platt.

Elishis, an OBKLA board member and sponsor of the event, said the evening was a success and demonstrated what can be accomplished when people of different backgrounds come together toward a common goal.

"There's no better way to bring people together than working alongside one another for a greater cause, feeding not just those struggling with food insecurity but also ourselves," Elishis said. "This was an incredible evening of unity and friendship that will hopefully have ripple effects in both our communities during these difficult times."

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